Jack's Research Lab
Research Note 001

Retro Video Games as Investment Assets

A Comparative Analysis of Collectibles, Equities, Gold, and Inflation

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Research Question: Can collectibles outperform traditional assets?

Abstract

This research note examines whether selected retro video games produced returns comparable to traditional financial assets. Using estimated historical loose-copy prices from PriceCharting and current market values, four collectible games are compared against SPY, gold, and inflation. The strongest performer in the sample was Rule of Rose, which turned a hypothetical $100 allocation into approximately $2,260. The analysis covers approximately 17–19 years of market history depending on asset availability.

Study Design

Research Question	Can selected retro games outperform traditional assets?
Study Period	Approx. 2007–2026
Asset Class	Collectibles, equities, gold, and inflation
Price Basis	Loose-copy video game market values
Benchmark Assets	SPY, GLD, and CPI inflation
Normalization	Each asset begins at $100

Main Results

Key Findings

- Rule of Rose was the top performer, substantially exceeding SPY, gold, and inflation.
- Pokemon Emerald also outperformed SPY over the estimated period.
- Fire Emblem: Path of Radiance and EarthBound appreciated meaningfully, but slightly trailed SPY.
- The results suggest that scarcity, nostalgia, and cultural significance can create asset-like returns in collectible markets.

Table 1: Growth of a Hypothetical $100 Investment (2007–2026)

Asset	Start Year	Multiple	Ending Value	Annualized Return
Rule of Rose	2009	22.60x	$2,259.53	17.8%
Pokemon Emerald	2007	9.27x	$926.76	12.4%
SPY	2007	7.48x	$748.30	11.2%
Fire Emblem: Path of Radiance	2007	6.84x	$683.77	10.6%
EarthBound	2007	6.29x	$628.84	10.2%
Gold	2007	6.21x	$620.65	10.1%
Inflation	2007	1.64x	$164.17	2.6%

Note: Historical video game prices were estimated using long-run PriceCharting loose-copy charts and current market values.

Economic Interpretation

The purpose of this project is not to argue that video games should be treated as conventional investments. Instead, the goal is to examine how economic value can emerge in collectible markets.

Scarcity

Physical retro games have fixed or declining supply. Once production ends, new original copies are not created. Over time, copies are lost, damaged, discarded, or absorbed into permanent collections.

Nostalgia Demand

Demand can increase years after release as consumers age, gain disposable income, and seek to reconnect with childhood or adolescent experiences. This creates a delayed demand curve that is unusual for many consumer goods.

Cultural Significance

Some games become cultural artifacts. Rule of Rose, EarthBound, and Pokemon Emerald each developed collector interest beyond ordinary entertainment value. In these cases, the market is not pricing only playability. It is pricing story, reputation, rarity, and identity.

Market Inefficiency

Retro game markets are fragmented and relatively illiquid. Prices may be influenced by small sample sizes, condition differences, authenticity concerns, and collector psychology. These features can create unusual appreciation, but also meaningful risk.

Limitations

This analysis should be interpreted as a research exercise, not investment advice. Several limitations are important:

- Historical game prices were visually estimated from long-run charts.
- Transaction costs, selling fees, taxes, and shipping costs were not included.

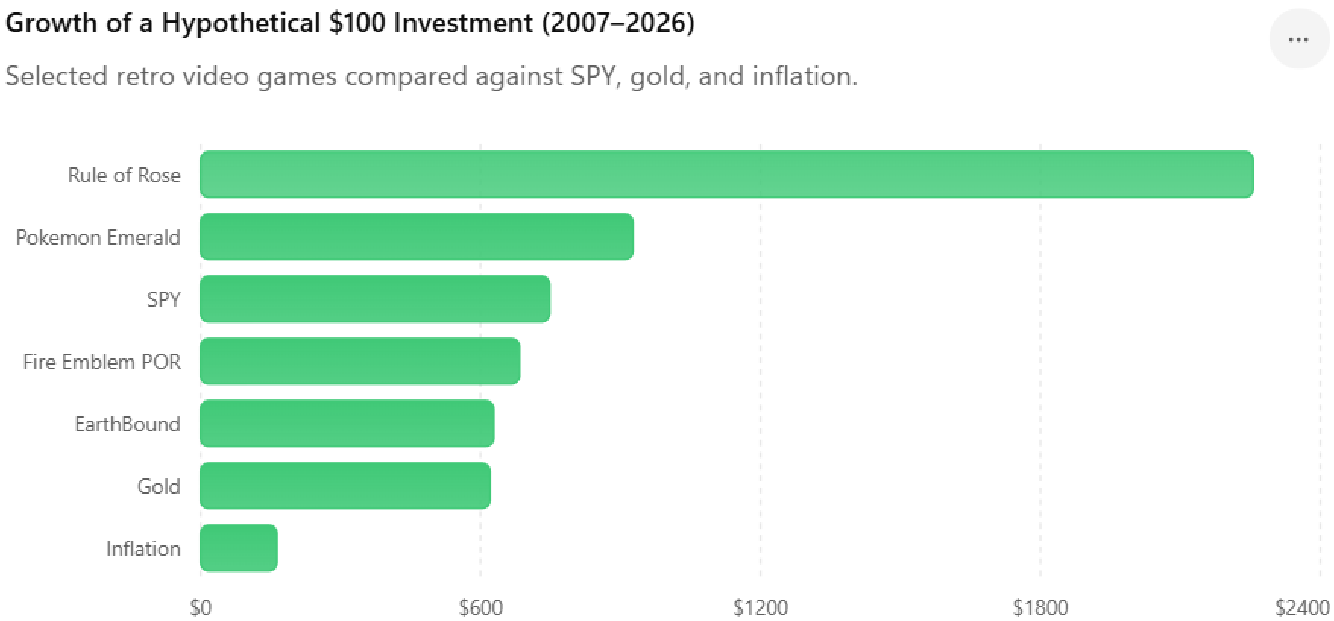

Figure 1: Comparative Asset Performance (2007–2026)

- Condition differences can materially affect collectible values.
- Collectibles are less liquid than stocks, ETFs, or commodities.
- The strongest performers are likely exceptional cases rather than representative outcomes.

A broader version of this study would include a larger sample of games, transaction-level data, condition categories, and a formal collectible index.

Data Sources

Video game price estimates were obtained from PriceCharting historical loose-copy market values. Equity market returns were estimated using SPY as a proxy for the S&P 500. Gold returns were estimated using GLD. Inflation estimates were based on U.S. Consumer Price Index data.

Conclusion

Some retro video games can beat the stock market, at least within this selected sample. The deeper lesson is broader than gaming: markets assign value to scarcity, nostalgia, cultural significance, and story.

In this sample, the winner was not a technology stock, a commodity, or a market index.

It was a strange PlayStation 2 horror game.

Future research may examine larger samples of retro games, trading cards, and other collectible markets to determine whether these findings generalize beyond a small set of standout titles.

Jack's Research Lab
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